

MID-LIFE CAREER: CONTINUOUS LEARNING

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8/09/2005

ABSTRACT

This paper presents a perspective on the midlife career of a professional facing tough decisions: improve the current career, pursue other opportunities, or learn new skills. It is not an offering of advice to anyone, but it may provide some useful information and self-help case studies. As professionals approaching their 40s and 50s, they fear losing their jobs and pursue other opportunities, personal interests, and continuous learning. This paper examines the impact on mid-life professionals and their career decisions. The studies include my personal experiences, practical knowledge, and those of other professionals facing the same issues in career transition. These issues remain in long-standing professions, in changing careers, or in continuing learning. As a high-tech professional, learning is essential for surviving in this fast-moving career. The struggle includes a midlife career transition, which can be painful and potentially dangerous. This paper also provides case studies examining methods that illuminate how professionals must deal with workplace trauma, learning, continuous learning, and career next moves.

KEYWORDS

Midlife career crisis; career assessments; career decision; career plan; continuous learning; lifelong learning

INTRODUCTION

The definition of midlife career is very different from a person's midlife expectancy. In fact, with people living so much longer and healthier, midlife expectancy has increased due to advances in medical technology. According to the U.S. Census Bureau, in 1900 life expectancy was 47 years, and in 2000 it was 77 years, with life expectancy rising [5]. So, the definition of mid-life expectancy would be around ages 24 and 39 for the two periods, respectively. Here is a definition from Random House Unabridged Dictionary:

“a period of psychological stress occurring in middle age, thought to be triggered by a physical, occupational, or domestic event, as menopause, diminution of physical prowess, job loss, or departure of children from the home.”

The current retirement age is 65, and there is also a proposal by the U.S. Congress to raise it to 67. The first “real job” is at the age of 24. According to the U.S. Census Bureau in 2000, about 24 million young adults were still in graduate school and had not yet had their first “real job”. These data show that people have to work for at least 44 years over their lifetimes. Statistically, midlife is at age 46. And there are an additional 12 or more years you are expected to live, bringing the life expectancy to 77.

Considering people are living longer, with midlife at 77 and mid-career at 65, you have to keep working well into your 80s, 90s, and even into your hundreds. That is a scary feeling to stay working on a job for such a long time. One thought is that there are many opportunities for career changes and plenty of time to succeed, continue learning new skills, and retool. The reality is not really having the pleasure of trying new things or switching to a new career. One can only hope to plan a career well, which may provide an opportunity to pursue another career and fulfill a lifelong dream. For a mid-life professional, time is really at the essence, and the choice is at the moment. What are you going to do? There are ups and downs, life is twisted in different directions, and therefore there are many unknowns and uncertainties about my future career, but one thing is clear: a plan is needed. The factors involved in my decision-making include family, financial, and career. Midlife career decision: it can be very stressful and scary, like going into a job interview unprepared. To prepare for a mid-life career, what one needs to know is understanding yourself, your strengths, your capabilities, your potential, and knowing how to get there from here.

Midlife career is a period of change that includes psychological stress, physical and occupational changes, and job loss. Psychological stress at work is a feeling of burnout and social interaction. Based on theories of social conflict, verbal aggression, self-esteem-threatening behavior, and concepts of reciprocity, fairness, and justice, a person might experience stressful interactions with others [2]. Physical stress at work occurs when your body is physically incapable, and it is a period of change marked by physical and emotional strain. Occupational stress is about your career. Considering these questions when sorting out your life, family, economic, and career: Here are a few questions: Do you like what you are doing now? Are you satisfied with your career? Are you happy with your job? What would you really like to be doing right now? Be as specific as you can with your answer of likes and dislikes.

In today's job market, you have to be very competitive. The fear of job loss is very real. When a mid-lifer loses a job, it's a trauma. Ho Nguyen, a 55-year-old friend of mine who lost his job as a System Integrator, put it all into words when he said, "It's not just a job; it's my life." Most mid-life professionals were raised to believe that work has value beyond earning a living. When you're successful and have a job, it tells people who you are, and where you fit in society. To lose a job means failure to them, and no explanation can change that perception. According to OSHA, stress from job insecurity has skyrocketed. A 1999 government study reported that more jobs had been lost in the previous year than any other year in the last century, and that the number of workers fearful of losing their jobs had more than doubled over the past decade. That was several years ago, and the problem has worsened considerably since then. A February 2000 poll found that almost 50 percent of employees were concerned about retaining their jobs, and with good reason. There were massive layoffs due to downsizing and bankruptcies, including the collapse of more than 200 dot-com companies. The unemployment rate by the end of the year was the highest it had been in 16 months. Nor have things improved since then. A report released on September 10, 2001, stated, "more than 1 million Americans lost their jobs this year, 83% higher than last year's total [4].

Mid-life Career Crisis

Thinking about mid-life career next move is also an essential part of being prepared. To survive in today's job market, making a career transition is a must. Yes, it is no question that it is a major concern, but changing careers at any age can be a little nerve-racking. Until you realize that someone who's been in a job for twenty-plus years is suddenly let go as part of corporate downsizing. That is going to hit you really hard. Adults approaching the age of 40: several factors keep many in jobs they would otherwise be let go of. These factors include age discrimination, opportunity to further education, and much-needed encouragement to get started. Being high-paid and overqualified does not help you for the rest of your career or in landing your next exciting job. Among many other reasons, professionals are facing stiff competition from younger professionals with less experience who earn less, yet they are competing for the same kind of job. In today's society, the threat of losing your job is very real, and companies are forced to let people go. The question of when layoffs will occur is genuinely worrying for professionals. Making a career change can be daunting, but perhaps more so in middle age. Most seasonal professionals don't relish having to relive the "what am I going to do next?" soul-searching they might have last experienced right after college. But if you take the perspective that there are still years to plan and do things, the change can be very exciting. Many professionals are facing their first job hunt as a mid-life career-daunting prospect. Many people have thoughts of a career change during mid-life but are not sure how to approach such a crucial decision. The challenge of successfully navigating a midlife career change is both exciting and stressful. The thing about mid-life is taking charge of your career. It's a question of having a how-to attitude and seeing mid-life not as over-the-hill but as being at the top of the hill, with the view at its best.

Continuous Learning

One way to overcome anxiety in mid-life career is to keep your skills current, which should be part of continuous and lifelong learning. Continuous learning is becoming a part of reality for professionals, and it's about survival: keeping their skills current or otherwise being replaced. So, what type of learning is available? Keeping in mind that training options that work for some people might not work for others, so be selective in your choice. For professionals, many types of training are available, including on-the-job training, online training, classroom training, and self-training. Depending on the type of training, there are advantages and disadvantages; find out what works for you.

As part of your planning, it's a good idea to take an inventory of skills. One way to get started is to take a blank sheet of paper and brainstorm skills or jobs you have most enjoyed over the years. It is also a good idea to consider past work history, hobbies, and experiences when filling in your list. This will help you in determining training that best fits your needs.

Training on the job

Companies are getting creative about providing on-the-job training, looking more closely at learning and training opportunities, and deciding which training will make the greatest difference in an employee's performance. They are offering in-house courses in just about everything, from personal development to technology. Most of courses are Web-based interactive, with this in mind. The courses can be taken anywhere and anytime. They consist of small modules. Material is available online and offline, on a compact disc, or even printed out. Some companies are also providing both computer-based and instructor-led training, on company time. Courses offered by the employer are monitored, and the employer tracks employees' progress by which courses they have completed and whether they have passed the test.

Most people take courses designed in-house by their employer and complete them on their own time. If you want to go into a different field, you need to find out what is available; consult a course catalog. Most employers allow everyone to take any of the courses. You need to find out exactly how to prepare from training and learning experience. As the skills needed within specific disciplines change, companies may need to ensure they are constantly refreshing those skills so people have a relevant skill set that meets industry needs.

Most companies also offer external training as part of their education reimbursement programs. This type of training is usually more costly and requires management approval. The courses taken are job-related and will maintain or improve skills required by the individual in his/her employment with the company. This program is mostly for highly valued employees and is monitored by management. If training is available to you, then go for it. There are lots of employees in school after hours and getting a lot of use for their money. Most employees are attending private university, community college, and seminars. Basically, whatever training is work for them.

Learning on your own

Learning on your own is considered a form of lifelong learning. It is about improving your current skills, learning new ones, and discovering what you are most passionate about. The courses range from technology, personal development, and social development. This type of learning is available at home, in the community, and at school. Some people are going back to school to earn a higher degree for career advancement, while others are going back to school to fulfill a lifelong career dream.

Something to consider: going back to school is costly and requires time, money, and commitment. Scheduling around work, family, and school is a big issue.

Motivation

Motivation is the key. A highly motivated person can get the full advantage of whatever training is available. How many of us would describe ourselves as highly motivated? If someone is standing over your shoulder, making you do the work, well, there's a good chance you'll keep putting it off until the last minute. Most of us need that little extra kick in the pants--promised reward, employment, bonus, promotion, or even simply public recognition--in order to excel at what we do. Keeping up with your co-workers and impressing your boss are strong motivators, and it's all about recognition.

At the end of training, one hopes to have really improved one's skills.

References

1. Jean Erickson Walker (2000), *The Age Advantage: Making the Most of Your Midlife Career Transition*, Berkley Trade
2. Dormann, C. & Zapf, D. (2004), *Journal of Occupational Health Psychology*, 9, 61-82.
3. The National Institute of Occupational Health and Safety issued a proposal for an Ergonomics Program Standard, <http://www.osha.gov>
4. The National Institute for Occupational Safety and Health (NIOSH), <http://www.cdc.gov/niosh/stresswk.html>
5. William Bridges (2003), *Creating You & Co: Learn to Think like the Ceo of Your Own Career*, Perseus Books Group; 2nd Exp&Up edition
6. U.S. Census Bureau, <http://www.census.gov/>

Annotations

Jean Erickson Walker, *The Age Advantage: Making the Most of Your Midlife Career Transition*,

p. 208: “Don’t be competitive. Your age advantage is that everyone expects you to have expertise and knowledge. You can afford to be generous.”

Jean Erickson Walker, *The Age Advantage: Making the Most of Your Midlife Career Transition*,

p. 294: “[C] companies do not hire someone over age fifty with the expectation of ‘developing’ them. Promotions may come, but they’re rare...”

Jean Erickson Walker, *The Age Advantage: Making the Most of Your Midlife Career Transition*,

p. 156: “Note: the high tech industry has dramatically changed the look of corporate America, where ‘cool’ and ‘laid-back’ are the right look. If you don’t want to stand out like a sore thumb, lose the pinstripes. It’s not necessary to go directly to rumpled blue jeans and tennis shoes, but you should look like you could do so comfortably on a moment’s notice. Nothing says you’re from a different generation quicker than being too formally dressed.”

Toddi Gutner, *when you still want to work*, Academic Search Premier, ISSN: 0007-7135, 17610666

SEVEN STEPS TO A ROUSING SECOND ACT

1. CARVE out a reason chunk of time to give serious thought to what you want to do next.
2. REFLECT on all the jobs you’ve ever had—volunteer as well as paid—and consider what you liked about each.
3. THINK about any ambitions you had in your youth that got derailed by practical considerations.
4. IDENTIFY how you spend your discretionary income. That will help you see your priorities.
5. FIGURE out ways you can marry your passions with your skills.
6. LOOK for opportunities in fields that have labor shortages and welcome older workers.
7. GO BACK to school, if necessary, to get the training and credentials you need.

William Bridges, *Creating You & Co: Learn to Think like the Ceo of Your Own Career*

Genuine beginnings begin within us, even when they are brought to our attention by external opportunities.